

WEAK THESIS STATEMENTS: RECOGNIZING AND FIXING THEM

A strong thesis makes a claim that (1) requires analysis to support and evolve it and (2) offers some point about the significance of your evidence that would not have been immediately obvious to your readers. By contrast, a weak thesis either makes no claim or makes a claim that does not need proving.

Five kind of weak thesis statements—ones that

1. make no claim (“This paper will examine the pros and cons of...”);
2. are obviously true or are a statement of fact (“Exercise is good for you”);
3. restate conventional wisdom (“Love conquers all”);
4. offer personal conviction as the basis for the claim (“Shopping malls are wonderful places”); and
5. make an overly broad claim (“Individualism is good”).

WEAK THESIS TYPE 1: THE THESIS MAKES NO CLAIM

I’m going to write about Darwin’s concerns with evolution in *The Origin of Species*.

This paper will address the characteristics of a good corporate manager.

These examples name a subject and link it to the intention to write about it, but they don’t make any claim about that subject. There is, in short, nothing at stake, no issue to be resolved.

Solution: *Raise specific issues for the essay to explore. Possible examples:*

Darwin’s concern with survival of the fittest in *The Origin of Species* leads him to neglect a potentially conflicting aspect of his theory of evolution—survival as a matter of interdependence.

The very trait that makes for an effective corporate manager—the drive to succeed—can also make the leader domineering and therefore ineffective.

WEAK THESIS TYPE 2: THE THESIS IS OBVIOUSLY TRUE OR IS A STATEMENT OF FACT

PROBLEM EXAMPLES

The jeans industry targets its advertisements to appeal to young adults.

If few people would disagree with the claim that a thesis makes, there is no point in writing an analytical paper on it.

Solution: Find some avenue of INQUIRY

Like conventional wisdom, personal likes and dislikes can lead inexperienced writers into knee-jerk reactions of approval or disapproval, often expressed in a moralistic tone. The writers of the problem examples above assume that their primary job is to judge their subjects or testify to their worth, not to evaluate them analytically

Solution: Try on other points of view honestly and dispassionately; treat your ideas as hypotheses to be tested rather than obvious truths. Possible examples...

Sir Thomas More's *Utopia* proposes an unworkable set of solutions to society's problems because, like communist Russia, it suppresses individualism.

WEAK THESIS TYPE 5: THE THESIS MAKES AN OVERLY BROAD CLAIM

Violent revolutions have had both positive and negative results for man.

Othello is a play about love and jealousy.

Overly generalized theses avoid complexity. At their worst, as in the examples above, they settle for assertions broad enough to fit almost any subject and thus say nothing in particular about the subject at hand.

Solution: Convert broad categories and generic claims to more specific assertions; find ways to bring out the complexity of your subject. Possible examples...

Although violent revolutions begin to redress long-standing social inequities, they often do so at the cost of long-term economic dysfunction and the suffering that attends it.

Although *Othello* appears to attack jealousy, it also supports the skepticism of the jealous characters over the naïveté of the lovers.
